

On Reverence

Bertrand Russell
(1872-1970)

In his writings on social and cultural issues, Bertrand Russell is at his best when he questions beliefs whose truth is taken for granted and attitudes which are hallowed by traditions. In "On Reverence" he shows how emotions of reverence, when invested thoughtlessly, can result in intellectual paralysis and cultural stagnation. His lucid and incisive observations on the topic should provide food for thought to intellectuals who abdicate their role as critics of their societies because of non-discriminating reverence for their heroes and cult-figures.

Admiration of great men, both of our own time and of the past, is a valuable emotion and a stimulus to useful activity. To young men of vigour and enterprise, the achievements of predecessors are an encouragement and a proof of what is possible to achieve.

But if this good effect is to result from admiration, it is necessary that the men who are admired should be regarded as something that it is possible to equal by means of sufficient exertion, not as something outside our capacity. It is possible to use the great men of the past as an excuse for laziness, by assuming that what they thought was perfect for all time and need never be re-examined.

This attitude is defended by those who adopt it, who call it 'reverence' and condemn all modern initiative as disrespectful. 'Reverence' in this sense has been a misfortune to the human race.

One of the most outstanding examples of the harm done by excessive reverence is the influence of Aristotle. For a brief period, in the eleventh and twelfth centuries, when the West rediscovered him through contact with the Arabs, his writings acted as an intellectual stimulus. But very soon he became the canon of orthodoxy, and no advance could be made except by showing the falsehood of what he had said.

Galileo could not induce professors of astronomy to look through his telescope at Jupiter's moons, because they knew from Aristotle that Jupiter has no moons. Throughout Galileo's life he was as much criticised for disagreeing with Aristotle as for his supposed conflict with the Scriptures.

Two centuries later, when Darwin published *Origin of Species*, he was met by dogmatic assertion of Aristotle's doctrine that each species was separately created. In logic and aesthetics his influence has been, and still is, exceedingly pernicious.

In the main, however, Aristotle's influence belongs to the past. But the attitude of appealing to the authority of great men as unquestionable has by no means disappeared. Every young man or young woman whose opinions are not on all points those of the older generation is met with arguments inspired by this point of view. 'Do you think you are wiser than so-and-so?' says the indignant parent or teacher. 'So-and-so' is almost always a man who himself disagreed with his parents and teachers, but this fact is ignored. 'So-and-so' lived in other circumstances and necessarily did not know all sorts of things that are known nowadays. Even if 'So-and-so' was just as wise as conservatives suppose, that is no reason for supposing that his opinions are to be accepted as a guide in the circumstances of the present day.

There is no subject upon which the opinions of a man who lived long ago can be accepted as dogmas absolving us from the necessity of fresh consideration in the light of our modern environment. Not infrequently, however, men who have acquired great authority never were very wise, even in their own day. One way of being thought wise is to defend current prejudices in glowing and eloquent language so that rhetoric conceals the lack of reasoning power and the failure of sympathetic understanding.

Great writers and great orators have done incalculable harm in this way. If eloquence could be made illegal, the dangers of popular government would be much less than they are. As, however, this solution is impossible, the only way out lies in an educational system which cultivates an inquiring and scientific outlook. Perhaps, after another two or three centuries, this way out may be tried.

Discussion

Why reverential attitude towards great men leads to intellectual stagnation?

What should be the proper attitude towards one's revered heroes?

What are negative and positive aspects of reverence for great men?